problems: an agency or a country which cannot attract the necessary loyalty. From this point of view, the Snowden fiasco exemplifies not only problems inside America, but also in its relations with the rest of the world. Spying on allies is a mere irritant when those alliances are strong. When they are weak, it becomes a source of incendiary rows. In Brazil, Indonesia, Mexico, Germany and many other countries, America no longer enjoys the image it once had. Relationships have decayed; trust has ebbed. This is not a new problem. George W Bush's administration made a bonfire of American soft power with its botched war in Iraq. In different ways, the Obama administration's remote, chilly and arrogant style has compounded the damage.

The rush of secret material into the public realm has distracted opinion from the real issues: motives, benefits and damage. In the best case, Snowden is a misguided whistleblower and his allies are merely reckless and naïve. By whatever mixture of luck and skill they have successfully safeguarded the most damaging and sensitive material and it will never reach our enemies. The public debate is better informed. He has delivered, perhaps, some salutary shocks.

If so, all that comes at a great cost. We have lost capabilities built up with great expenditure of time, money and skill. Our alliances are strained and our standing in the world has suffered. The price is too high.

The nightmare is that the truth is far worse: Snowden is a pawn in a hostile and continuing intelligence and information-warfare operation, with allthe extra damage which that implies. Either way, Snowden's actions are no cause for comfort, let alone celebration.

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[1] Of which he has won several, including from the *Washington Post.*

[2] Often attributed to Lenin, this apocryphal saying was used in Cold War days to describe Westerners who helped the Soviet Union through their naïveté.